

Northbridge Supplies: Stakeholder Interview Notes

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Who we spoke to

Ten interviews in January 2026, plus the auditors' management letter. Interviewer: Felicia Oyeboode.

#	Name	Role
1	Helen Marsh	Finance Director
2	Daniel Okafor	AP Team Lead
3	Jade Thompson	AP clerk
4	Mark Reid	Operations Manager
5	Sophie Grant	Marketing Manager
6	Tom Ellis	Procurement Lead
7	Andrew Patel	Financial Controller
8	Kerry Walsh	Warehouse supervisor
9	Priya Shah	IT Business Systems Manager
10	Lisa Hart	Credit controller, Dunmore Packaging (supplier)

1. Helen Marsh, Finance Director

- Two key suppliers have threatened to stop deliveries. The audit point on duplicates must be closed before the next audit.
- Top priority: 95% of invoices paid on time.
- Budget: up to £30,000 this year if it pays back within 12 months. No new finance system.
- Her own £10k+ approvals pile up when she's away. She'd use a phone app.
- She'll back "no PO, no pay".

"We tried the workflow module in 2023 and it fizzled out. I don't want another project nobody owns."

2. Daniel Okafor, AP Team Lead

- About 1 in 4 invoices has a PO problem, worse at month-end.
- One clerk spends about a day a week chasing approvals. AP can't make managers act.
- Queries are tracked in an inbox folder and his own spreadsheet.
- Suppliers resend invoices when chasing. There's no system check for duplicates.
- Payment run: AP exports approved invoices on Wednesday, Andrew checks, Helen pays on Thursday.

"I can remind them, but I can't make them do anything."

3. Jade Thompson, AP clerk

- About 1 in 8 invoices still comes by post. Each takes around 10 minutes to type in.
- Portal invoices are the quickest to log.
- She spots duplicates by memory. A resent invoice with a slightly different reference gets through.
- At month-end, logging falls days behind.

"Half my afternoon is emails asking people if they've looked at something yet."

4. Mark Reid, Operations Manager

- Approval emails get lost among about 200 a day. He batches them, sometimes weekly.
- He won't approve if he can't see the PO or know the goods arrived. Delivery notes are on paper in the warehouse.
- Urgent repairs and haulage are often ordered by phone with no PO.
- No backup approver, so invoices wait when he's on leave.
- Reminders don't help. They're just more email.

"If I can't tell whether we actually received it, I'm not signing it off."

5. Sophie Grant, Marketing Manager

- Agencies work on monthly retainers with no PO.
- She's away at events about two days a week and often doesn't know an invoice is waiting.
- No backup approver.
- Her idea: one PO per agency at the start of each year.

"I'd approve them in a minute if they came to my phone."

6. Tom Ellis, Procurement Lead

- Raising a PO takes 10 to 15 minutes at a desk, too slow for urgent jobs.
- Services such as agencies and consultants rarely get a PO.
- Price mismatches usually come from added delivery charges or old price lists.
- About 15% of invoices come through the supplier portal.
- Supports "no PO, no pay" with 30 days' notice, a quick emergency PO form, and annual POs for retainers.

"If the PO process takes longer than the job, people will skip it."

7. Andrew Patel, Financial Controller

- Reviews about 100 invoices in each Wednesday payment run. No time to check each for duplicates.
- The system only warns about duplicates, and the warning is easy to click past. He wants it to block.
- Happy to be the only person who can release a blocked payment, with a reason recorded.
- Will chase suppliers to recover any duplicates.
- Willing to own the workflow module if Helen agrees.

"I'm not going to spot one invoice we paid the week before last."

8. Kerry Walsh, Warehouse supervisor

- Delivery notes are signed and filed in a box by date.

- Part deliveries are common, but only the warehouse knows.
- Managers ring several times a week to ask if something arrived.
- Supervisors already use handheld scanners for stock and could record deliveries on them.

"It's all there, it's just in a box."

9. Priya Shah, IT Business Systems Manager

- The approval workflow module was bought in 2022 and never used. It routes invoices, sends reminders, escalates, and has a phone app.
- The 2023 pilot failed because nobody in Finance owned it and the approval list was out of date.
- Approvers can see the PO in the app. Deliveries too, once recorded in the system.
- The duplicate check can be switched to "block" in a few days.
- Cost: about £25,000 to set up, plus £4,000 a year. Takes 8 to 10 weeks.

"The software works. We just didn't have the business side in place."

10. Lisa Hart, Dunmore Packaging (supplier)

- When an invoice is a week overdue, she emails copies of it. Same invoice number.
- Northbridge has paid Dunmore twice before. They hold it as a credit.
- Since mid-2025, Dunmore charges late-payment fees to customers who pay late, including Northbridge.
- She'd quote POs and use the portal if asked. Nobody has asked.

"If you told us you needed a PO number on every invoice, we'd put one on."

Auditors' management letter

The auditors found weak controls over duplicate supplier invoices and want proof of a working check by the next year-end audit.

Summary

Everyone described the same three problems, and the 2025 invoice data confirms each one.

Problem	Raised by	What the data shows
Invoices arrive with no PO or the wrong price	Daniel, Mark, Sophie, Tom, Lisa	28% of invoices; Marketing worst at 43.8%
Two managers are slow to approve	Daniel, Mark, Sophie	Operations 15.0 days and Marketing 11.8, others under 5
Duplicates get paid	Daniel, Jade, Andrew, Lisa, auditors	45 invoices paid twice, £158,776
Month-end backlog	Daniel, Jade	Logging takes 6.7 days in the last week, 1.4 otherwise
Chasing takes a day a week	Daniel	It's more: about 2,168 hours a year